> The situation has been further exacerbated by the interference of Pakistan directly and more so through its creation, the Taliban. The peace initiative launched by the United Nations under the Special Envoy of the UN Secretary General Ambassador Mestiri suggesting transfer of power as an interim arrangement was not found acceptable by all factions. As a result, prospects for a peaceful political settlement in the near future still remain uncertain'.[88]

In what top Afghanistan expert Amin Saikal calls an 'above the horizon' approach, UN mediators could not grasp the complexity of the Afghan problem.[89] Mestiri made the same mistakes as Sevan and could do little to pacify the situation on the ground. His overtly hostile stance towards the Rabbani government did little other than to attract strong rebuttals from the *Jamiat-e-Islami*.[90] The compelling failure of Mestiri's mission was underlined in the UNSC meeting on 9 April 1996, where it was concluded that foreign intervention in Afghanistan was thwarting international efforts to achieve a negotiated settlement to the conflict. The vice-minister for foreign affairs of Afghanistan told the council that the special mission had failed to explicitly identify foreign interference as the root cause of the conflict and to recommend effective measures to terminate it.[91] Dixit, writing in 1996 on the eve of Kabul's fall, worried that 'Afghanistan faces the prospect of not only turmoil and violence but also disintegration as a country if things are not brought under control soon'.[92] He worried that the UN and its special envoys to Afghanistan, Sevan and Mestiri, had not been able to reconcile the political, ethnic, or military contradictions in that situation.

The Taliban's takeover of Kabul in September 1996 crushed whatever little hope was left for the UN to intervene in Afghanistan. With Mestiri's mission an utter failure, the UN Resolution 1076 was little more than an exasperated sigh by the UN. Prakash Shah, India's representative to the UN in 1996, made it clear that India had been a principal victim of state-supported terrorism and its export from across its borders. 'It was essential that the main focus of United Nations' peace efforts in Afghanistan should be the cessation of hostilities and prevention of foreign interference and outside support to rebel forces', Shah noted.[93] Advocating caution and adopting an internationalist approach, Indian diplomacy was being steered by the conciliators till this point. With the Rao doctrine still somewhat influential, India was open to engaging with any faction that came to power in Kabul. Mestiri's failure to comprehend a highly fluid situation and